instructions to my col eagues and we felt a new surge of hope.

The next day Dr Mediratta brought a visitor to our hovercraft—a tal , handsome, bearded man. He asked me several questions about the machine. I was struck by the objectivity and clarity of his thinking. “Can you give me a ride in the machine?” he enquired. His request fil ed me with joy. Final y, here was someone who was interested in my work.

We took a ten-minute ride in the hovercraft, a few centimetres above the ground. We were not flying, but were definitely floating in the air. The visitor asked me a few questions about myself, thanked me for the ride and departed. But not before introducing himself—he was Prof. MGK Menon, Director of the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR). After a week, I received a cal from the Indian Committee for Space Research (INCOSPAR), to attend an interview for the post of Rocket Engineer. Al I knew about INCOSPAR at that time was that it was formed out of the TIFR talent pool at Bombay (now Mumbai) to organize space research in India.

I went to Bombay to attend the interview. I was unsure